

they never stray from tabloid headlines. They are also in complete control of their image—in as much as it is possible in these open access times.

So Basu's endorsements—Reebok Worldwide, D'damas, Reliance group, Kinetic sym-scooty, and Zapak games—are handled by Carving Dreams, a celebrity agency that handles only a select handful, Roshan, Kajol and Ajay Devgan, apart from her. "There's a lot of paperwork to be done," she says. So much that she is on the verge of letting go of her film secretary, she says, because he hasn't upgraded his skills. "The image I have is one of someone who means business. I can't have someone who radiates the opposite." As someone who has the best website in the business, she knows what she's talking about. Kaif's business deals are managed by Matrix, who earlier handled Deepika Padukone—the newbie seems to be following Kaif's trajectory of ramp modelling, Kingfisher calendar and controversial love life. Kaif also endorses Godrej, Spice Telecom, and Marico. Kapoor, apart from having shot for every glossy cover in recent months, increasingly becoming the incredible shrinking woman, endorses Globus, ICI Paints, Head and Shoulders, Boroplus and Citizen watches, also through Matrix.

All of them are sisters of the spotlight, who have made mistakes. So if Kaif was awful in *Boom* before modelling launched her as a pretty face ("Hey, I was just a child," she says, "I didn't even know where my interests lay"), then Basu also made mistakes ("but they were my mistakes"). So did Kapoor, who has gone on record often to say how she regretted asking for too much and losing out on *Kal Ho Naa Ho*, produced by Karan Johar.

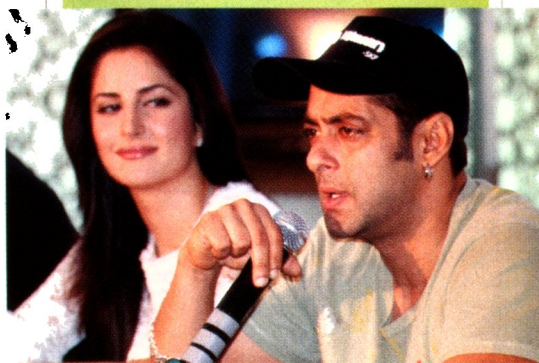
All these girls of summer have learnt from the woman who is still, at 34, on the top of every director's wishlist, Rai, who charges Rs 3 crore, has not only survived Bollywood politics but also driven a hard bargain. Rai, who came to Bollywood from modelling, emphasised written agreements and even walked out of *The*

COLLATERAL BENEFIT

They are the It Girls with the right accessory: a lovestruck boyfriend.



DNA DIVA: Saif Ali Khan tattoos her name on his arm. Shahid Kapur went into a blue funk for her. Kapoor's real love life gives her a youthful appeal and with *Tashan*, the dynasty's child's PR machine is dropping hints about a Hollywood career.



THE NEWBIE: Usually seen as a pretty and silent prop in Salman Khan's busy life, Kaif, who still can't speak much Hindi, is busy delivering hits. Her next big roles in *Singh is Kinning* and *Yuvraaj* look likely to get her lots of airtime.



GLAM GAL: Whether she kisses Ronaldo or cuts her hair, Basu is in the news. Her relationship with John Abraham ensures she's a tabloid hottie. *Dhoom 2* solidified her bling quotient as will *Race*.

Rising because she felt she was not getting paid in proportion to the male star, Aamir Khan. Her colourful off-screen life, unacknowledged unlike Kapoor-Basu-Kaif, also gave her a notoriety beyond her film career. And while Rai was still old school enough to cling to an old fashioned secretary (who had also worked with Sridevi) and her mum for company, these clone princesses love their families but don't always flaunt them. Bollywood can be a very lonely place, especially for women, and with a mother/sister to come back to, it's easier to deal with. So no surprise that Kaif's younger sister, 16-year-old Izabelle (they are two of seven daughters of a British mother and Indian father) is keeping her company in her house in Mumbai, till she goes to university.

Yet movies which focus entirely on women rarely work at the box-office. A Madhur Bhandarkar film, which tends to have strong female protagonists, is sold on the basis of the director's name. Even the Rs 18-crore *Fashion*, which Bhandarkar is currently shooting with Priyanka Chopra, another actor who makes news for her personal life as much as for her movies, is attracting interest for its content rather than its cast. Chopra's done the pretty-prop-to-big-hero route in *Don* and *Krrish* and with *Fashion*, she is clearly gunning for artistic acceptance. The busy actor has also signed a Rs 20-crore deal with UTV for three films, which ensures that along with her current projects—*Drona*, *Love Story 2050* and a Karan Johar-produced movie—she will have no time to spare till 2009. It's a road Kapoor has already travelled, doing the edgy *Chameli* and *Omkara*, with more mainstream pulp. Like her emerging contemporaries, Kapoor's sense of self is strong, which is evident in her business decisions, whether it is changing publicists or demanding proper payments. In last year's *Jab We Met*, Geet, Kapoor's character says, "Main apni favourite hoon (I am my favourite)." For these girls aloud, it's like a declaration of independence they can all sign on. Because, as Ali puts it, if they don't push for themselves, no one else will. ■